



COLORADO
Office of Economic Security
Division of Employment & Benefits

Colorado's Section 20 Optional Workfare Program

State Plan for FFY26

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Colorado plans to operate a Section 20 Optional Workfare program in Federal Fiscal Year 2026 (FFY26) for work registrants. County Departments of Human Services (DHS) that operate the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program's Employment and Training (SNAP E&T) program, known as Employment First (EF) in Colorado, have the option to operate a Section 20 Optional Workfare Program. At the time of this plan submission, the Section 20 Optional Workfare Program will operate in 16 of Colorado's 64 counties for FFY26.

Colorado's philosophy is that workfare provides a stepping stone to paid employment while providing valuable service to the community. Through a robust network of workfare sites, Colorado can connect clients with a wide array of employers where they can build relevant skills and gain valuable work experience. In FFY26, Colorado will continue to align, where possible, workfare sites with Colorado's key industries to meet local business needs and ensure that the skill development directly ties to the interest and aptitude of each client and the local labor market.

Colorado's key industries include:

- Healthcare and Social Assistance
- Administrative Support and Waste Management Remediation Services
- Professional, Scientific, and Technical Services
- Retail Trade
- Manufacturing
- Accommodation and Food Service
- Educational Services
- Finance and Insurance
- Information
- Construction
- Wholesale Trade

In FFY26, the Section 20 Optional Workfare Program will operate as a voluntary program. As a voluntary program, any eligible work registrant can access program services. Work registrants will not be sanctioned for electing not to participate in the Section 20 Optional Workfare Program. The table below lists each county DHS with a Section 20 Optional Workfare Program, and the number of workfare sites in the county.

Adams (8)	Arapahoe (44)	Boulder (5)	Broomfield (4)	Weld (5)	Denver (24)	Douglas (36)
Eagle (2)	Garfield (13)	Jefferson (22)	Larimer (2)	Logan (18)	Prowers (7)	Chaffee (1)
Montrose (11)	Morgan (19)					

Colorado has 234 workfare sites statewide. County DHS continues to identify, develop, and contract with value-added workforce sites. The local workfare coordinator in each County DHS department develops its own Section 20 Optional Workfare sites. The EF program tracks the workfare sites each County DHS utilizes, averaging roughly 14 workfare sites per county.

These workfare sites are located in a variety of public and nonprofit agencies which include but are not limited to: County DHS, Colorado Department of Transportation, Habitat for Humanity ReStores, Habitat for Humanity, public schools, museums, daycare centers, homeless projects, hospitals, homeless shelters, libraries, senior centers, Native American centers, historic sites, public radio stations, community colleges, humane societies, food and clothing banks, workforce centers, parks and recreation departments, road & bridge departments, non-profit organizations such as Goodwill, Arc Thrift Stores, the Salvation Army, the Red Cross, Meals on Wheels, women's shelters, and counseling centers.

Some examples of Section 20 Optional Workfare job classifications are: data entry clerk, clerical/receptionist, medical/nursing assistant, computer operator, building inspector, daycare worker, landfill worker, cemetery staff, teacher's aide, peer counselor, job coach, gardener, food service worker, van driver, general laborer, maintenance, cashier, painter, customer service representative, carpenter, tutor for English as a second language, bookkeeper, marketing clerk, dietary aide, counselor, cook, inmate intake/release monitor, interpreter, forest service worker, construction worker, mailroom clerk, landscaper, historical guide, animal caretaker, retail clerk, senior aide, public radio station staff, researcher, librarian aide, telephone operator, bus aide, warehouse worker, and hospice worker.

A program orientation, assessment, and an individualized service plan are completed by the workfare coordinator or an EF case manager before and throughout the workfare site placement. The assessment includes, but is not limited to: strengths, interests, and or/ability tests, screening for employment barriers, evaluation of work history, and education. During their participation in workfare, each client is encouraged to work on three job search competencies, including the completion of a master job application/resume, formulation of a detailed job search plan, and development of job interviewing skills.

Both the client and the workfare coordinator agree upon the workfare assignment. Concerted efforts are made to begin workfare at the initial EF program appointment. Every attempt is made to make a successful match based on the abilities and interests of each client while targeting training in a convenient location. Workfare coordinators provide written job descriptions, skills to be learned, and hours of operation for each workfare site so clients can choose which workfare site best meets the client's needs and aligns with career interests. In many cases, clients may engage in a 30-day supervised job search prior to or following their application or recertification appointment for SNAP benefits (dependent upon the needs of the client). Clients are then assessed within 14 days from the date of the referral by an EF case manager. After this period, the client may be assigned to a workfare site. Before placement, the workfare coordinator visits the workfare site to ensure that a safe and positive working environment exists.

A written agreement detailing the responsibilities of both the workfare site sponsor and the workfare coordinator is signed before a client is placed in the workfare site. The written agreements shall be revisited at least every two years to ensure the workfare site continues to add value to the Section 20 Optional Workfare Program and is suitable for clients. To be suitable, a workfare site must meet the following criteria:

- not pose an unreasonable risk to health or safety
- be within the physical and mental capabilities of the client
- be within one hour's distance from the client's residence
- not interfere with a client's religious observances

- not be subject to a strike or lockout

For all workfare sites, clients receive a written notification that contains:

- Where and when to report
- The workfare site supervisor's name and phone number
- The job description
- The number of required hours
- The penalty for program non-compliance
- notification of eligibility
- The client's specific responsibilities
- Information on reimbursement for travel and other participation-related costs (that are covered through Section 20 Optional Workfare Participant reimbursements).

Required monthly workfare hours are determined by dividing the entire SNAP household grant by the prevailing Colorado minimum or federal minimum wage, whichever is higher. This year, the Colorado minimum wage is higher. Fractions of hours are always rounded down. The required hours cannot exceed eight hours per day or 30 hours per week. Workers' compensation is provided at all sites either by the individual workfare site or by the county DHS where the program operates.

Workfare coordinators monitor attendance and progress for all clients at least monthly. Interactive monthly follow-up groups can be offered as part of the Section 20 Optional Workfare Program. Follow-up groups can include client networking, a continuation of job-seeking skills, guest speakers, including employers that are currently hiring, and peer support and encouragement. Workfare site timesheets may also be collected at the monthly meetings. Client reimbursement for transportation or other needs that are reasonable and necessary (e.g., tools, clothing, fees) should be disbursed based on the client's assessed needs.

The timesheets include an evaluation form completed by the site director/supervisor, and case notes are created by the case managers and kept in the client's case file. The combined timesheet/evaluation form serves as client feedback and assists workfare coordinators in promptly addressing placement concerns. Clients use this feedback when job searching to show potential employers their current work habits. Often, contacts made at workfare sites are used as job references for future employment opportunities.

Any workers' compensation deductibles incurred by the county department of human/social services because of a client receiving a workplace injury during participation in workfare shall fall under the 50/50 administrative funding rules.

Lastly, county DHSs will support clients by assigning them to workfare sites in another county if the latter site better fits their needs than the one in their respective county.

Workfare Site Sponsor Responsibilities

- Provide an orientation or 1:1 appointment concerning workfare site rules and regulations.
- Provide an assignment that the client is capable of and interested in performing.
- Provide positive supervision and the necessary equipment to complete the assignment.
- Complete the timesheet/evaluation forms for each client every month when the client is engaged in the workfare site.
- Provide time off for a client's job interviews.
- Communicate any relevant issues, either concerning the client, the job application, or the general operation of the workfare site, to the workfare coordinator.

Client Responsibilities

- Observe the working hours and the work rules established by the workfare site.
- Communicate with the workfare site supervisor, workfare coordinator, or the EF case manager regarding workfare site progress or concerns.
- Notify the workfare coordinator or EF case manager immediately if the client stops participating in their workfare site placement.
- Turn in completed timesheets or other required paperwork digitally or in person at follow-up appointments.

Disqualification

ABAWDs are not subject to disqualifications for not participating in the Section 20 Optional Workfare Program at the time of this plan's submission.

Record Keeping

Written workfare site agreements are executed with all agencies and organizations that serve as workfare sites. These agreements are kept in a master file at each local agency (the county DHS or subcontractor) that operates the Section 20 Optional Workfare Program. In addition, county DHS or their sub-contractors must furnish the State with the names, addresses, and hours of specific clinics and doctors that will treat injured clients for workers' compensation purposes. This information is required for each workfare site. All workfare site agreements are reviewed, and a copy is retained by the state office. These agreements are updated when changes occur and at least every two years.

Case files, both electronic and hard copy, are maintained for each client. Case files include workfare sites, hours assigned, hours actually worked, timesheet/evaluation forms, and any communication with SNAP eligibility staff, workfare site sponsors, and the client. Case files that include an individual service plan, assessments, case notes, and other program-supporting documentation are maintained for audit and review purposes for at least three years from the month of origin for each Section 20 Optional Workfare program case.

Clients are seen at least monthly to review their progress at their workfare site. Each month, the client or the workfare site supervisor submits a timesheet/evaluation form to the workfare coordinator.

Reporting

Quarterly reports are available to the Mountains Plains Regional Office (MPRO) with the Food and Nutrition Service (FNS) office within 45 days after the end of each quarter. Reports are detailed by each county department of human/social services that operates a Section 20 Optional Workfare Program:

- Number of households referred,
- Number of households assigned to workfare sites,
- Number of individual clients assigned to workfare sites,
- The number of total hours worked by clients at workfare sites,
- Number of disqualifications due to workfare non-compliance (not applicable at the time of this plan submission),
- The date a client's SNAP allotment changed
- The amount of a client's SNAP allotment changed
- Employment wage
- The estimated amount of enhanced funding

Enhanced funding, also known as the workfare savings entitlement, occurs when a client begins unsubsidized employment after participating in workfare for the first time and within 30 days of ending their first participation in workfare. Quarterly reports also supply details on each client who generated enhanced funding.

Program Evaluation

Section 20 Optional Workfare Program agencies (county departments of human/social services and their sub-contractors) are monitored on an ongoing basis (at least once every two years) by State EF staff. This monitoring can include, but is not limited to:

- Virtual or on-site evaluations
- Interviews with local workfare coordinators
- Case file reviews
- Observation of orientations and assessments
- Evaluation of management practices
- Review of participation and enhanced funding reports
- Visits to workfare sites (if possible)
- Review of budget and program goals
- Examination of local operations to ensure compliance with state and federal regulations.

The State EF team provides technical assistance to Section 20 Optional Workfare Program agencies throughout the year. Last year (FFY25), Colorado produced updated workfare guidance, including documented procedures and forms. These serve as the State EF team's platform to communicate and deliver training regarding EF and the Section 20 Optional Workfare Program, including discussions regarding best practices, policies, and procedures. The State of Colorado will also host monthly workgroups in FFY26 to support program operations.

Hearing Procedure

Each individual or household has the right to a fair hearing to appeal a denial, reduction, or termination of benefits due to a determination of non-exempt status or failure to comply with the work registration requirement of workfare. If a fair hearing is requested, the household shall be allowed to examine its workfare case file before the hearing. Information not released to the household may not be used at the hearing. The results of the hearing shall be binding for the SNAP office.